JGA Payroll Research Plan

Proposed scope and practitioner questions

Prepared for Nick Day and Mark • Version 0.1 for review

We propose a report that connects what payroll leaders want to improve with the decisions that fund, delay or stop change. This pack sets out the readership, chapter structure and questions for review before practitioner collection begins.

The central research question

What do payroll leaders need, and what determines whether those needs become approved and delivered investment?

Who the report is for

Proposed primary readers are senior employer-side payroll leaders and the finance, HR and technology decision-makers who assess payroll investment. Start with UK-relevant responsibilities, including international remits. Employer-side users of outsourced payroll are included.

How the evidence will be built

- Review and reference existing industry research, then investigate specific decision cases rather than repeat a broad trends survey.
- Target 6–10 distinct verified senior payroll practitioner contributions through JGA introductions, subject to availability and permission.
- Use one recent decision per contributor where available, including success, renewal, delay, rejection and abandonment. Record needs and future priorities separately.
- Synthesize the evidence into a Payroll Investment Decision Framework. Qualitative contributions explain experiences; they do not establish representative market percentages.

What we need you to review

Please confirm the proposed audience and geography, chapter coverage and core questions. On page 5, we set out the introduction route, materials and dates to agree. The separate two-page prospectus can then support feedback from selected contacts.

Proposed report structure

Working title: The Payroll Investment and Transformation Report 2027. The edition year describes its planning focus; source and fieldwork dates will be recorded accurately.

The design target is approximately 20–24 pages including methods and references, adjusted to the evidence rather than used as a fixed limit. An executive summary opens the publication.

Part One What leaders want

1 Operating reality. What works today, where friction occurs, and what consequences make improvement important.

2 Technology and service needs. Specific capability and service gaps, workarounds and trade-offs across platforms, integration, automation, AI and outsourcing.

3 Priorities and commitment. What matters over the next 12–24 months, distinguishing desired improvements from evaluated, planned, funded and delivered work.

Part Two How investment decisions happen

4 The decision pathway. Who recommends, sponsors, funds, approves or can stop a proposal, and where conditions enter the process.

5 The business case. Which evidence decision-makers request, which evidence appears to matter, and how costs, benefits and alternatives are assessed.

6 Progress and constraints. What enables delivery, what changes the proposal, and why some investments are delayed, declined or abandoned.

7 Staying or switching. When renewal, an alternative supplier, a process change or deliberate no change is the chosen option.

Conclusion From Ambition to Investment

8 The practical framework. A repeatable route from an operational need to a credible case, decision and delivery review, grounded in the research.

Methods, references and evidence notes will make source populations, dates and permissions clear. Proposed case summaries and original graphics will be built from the collected evidence. No validated confidence index is assumed for this first edition.

Practitioner questions one to seven

Two short context questions precede the substantive guide. We ask open questions first and use only relevant follow-ups. Contributors may skip questions or avoid confidential details.

1 Role in decisions

What is your role in decisions about payroll technology, providers or major process changes?

Follow-up: recommending, evaluating, implementing or approving.

2 Operating context

How is payroll currently delivered in your area of responsibility?

Follow-up: in-house, outsourced or mixed delivery; broad scale and relevant countries.

3 Improvement priority

What, if anything, would you most like to improve about payroll in your organisation?

Follow-up: why it matters and what already works well.

4 Unmet needs

Where, if anywhere, do the payroll technology or services you use or have recently evaluated fall short of your needs?

Follow-up: a specific example, workaround, and whether available options are unsuitable.

5 Future priorities

Which payroll improvements, if any, do you expect your organisation to prioritise over the next 12–24 months?

For up to two priorities, distinguish ideas, evaluation, plans, approved funding and delivery. Ask about specific technologies only after the open answer.

6 Recent decision

Thinking about the past 24 months, what is the most recent payroll investment, provider renewal or proposed change in which you had direct involvement?

Record approximate timing and direct involvement. Without a recent case, skip questions 7–13 and go to question 14.

7 Decision reached

What decision had been reached on that proposal as of today?

Record approval, decline, deferral, withdrawal, pending or no formal approval required. Separately record delivery status and any change in the decision.

Practitioner questions eight to fourteen

Questions 8–13 refer to the same recent case. The final question is open to every eligible contributor.

8 Original trigger

What prompted this proposal or review?

Follow-up: organisational consequence, why then, and any deadline or opportunity.

9 Authority and influence

Who had the authority to approve or stop the proposal?

Follow-up: sponsor, budget owner, sign-off and veto roles. Record roles rather than names.

10 Evidence requested

What evidence, if any, was requested to assess the proposal?

Follow-up: costs and benefits, risk, continuity and delivery capacity, after the open answer.

11 Evidence that mattered

Which evidence, if any, appeared to influence the decision most?

If pending, ask what evidence has influenced the assessment so far. If deferred, retain the main question. For both, also ask what evidence is still needed.

12 Alternatives and choice

What other options were considered?

Then ask which option, if any, was selected and why. Keeping an incumbent is a choice, not the opposite of approval.

13 Conditions and constraints

What conditions or concerns, if any, most affected whether or when the proposal could proceed?

Ask what enabled progress too. If delivery has started, ask how results so far compare with what was agreed.

14 Next research question

What is one question about payroll investment that you think the profession should answer next?

Optional follow-up: advice for another payroll leader facing a similar decision.

Introductions and next decisions

Who would be useful to involve

Please forward the brief below to senior employer-side payroll leaders with direct involvement in technology, provider or major process decisions. We will seek varied experiences, including successful change and sensible renewal. A person without a recent case can still contribute to the needs and priorities sections.

Suggested introduction brief

JGA is commissioning The Payroll Investment and Transformation Report 2027, with research support from Riseklix. We are exploring what payroll leaders want to improve and what makes payroll investment get approved, delayed or abandoned.

We would value your perspective through a structured conversation or an equivalent written response, ideally drawing on a decision from the past 24 months. Participation is voluntary, and you can skip questions or avoid confidential details.

The findings are intended for a JGA publication that may also be commercially licensed. Any named quotation or identification of your employer would require separate permission. Would you be open to contributing? We can share the questions and practical arrangements before you decide.

The Table is a separate feasibility question

Alongside the report, we will assess research-only licensing and an event-supported research model. Up to four exploratory conversations are planned, ideally two potential commercial buyers and two prospective council members. Council members count toward the 6–10 only where they also provide an eligible, permissioned report contribution; each person is counted once.

Inputs and timing to agree

- Confirm the readership, geography, outline and questions, plus any essential topic we have missed.
- Nominate an introduction coordinator and supply JGA brand assets or publication examples.
- Agree collection tools, permissions and access arrangements before participant data is collected. Confirm the conversation length after a timing check.
- Confirm the kickoff, first-week checkpoint and review date. The working plan remains approximately three working weeks from the agreed kickoff, subject to timely access and feedback.

Once the focus and collection arrangements are agreed, we will retain the approved version and begin introductions and practitioner collection.